

Linguistic Literacy and Advocacy in Action

Case Studies in Community Engagement from the
Language Diversity Ambassadors at North Carolina State
University

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Introduction

Public access to and knowledge about scholarship in linguistics helps individuals understand the real-life impacts of linguistic stereotyping and discrimination. However, the responsibility for clear communication that scholars in the academy hold is often overlooked. Members of the public are not readily able to access articles buried in academic journals, so it is up to linguists to disseminate our findings in a way that makes them understandable by and pertinent to community members (see also Gawne et al., this volume). This

chapter is first and foremost constructed to provide actionable ideas and practical knowledge for the expansion of linguistic outreach programs.

Language Diversity Ambassadors (LDA) is a student organization of graduate students in linguistics and sociology at North Carolina State University who conduct linguistics outreach programs at the university itself, in the surrounding Raleigh community, and throughout the state of North Carolina. The organization has worked to make linguistics accessible and relevant to the lived experiences of community members by developing linguistics outreach programs. In particular, the organization has focused on giving people educational tools and knowledge to advocate for their linguistic practices and perspectives (Wolfram et al., 2004; Wolfram, 2013). Our primary programming focus is to explicitly and critically examine power hierarchies and how they are produced and reproduced by language (Godley & Minnici, 2008; Godley & Reaser, 2018). By working to increase community-wide awareness about linguistic stereotyping and discrimination, we seek to counter bias at the ideological level while working hard to disseminate the results of linguistic scholarship so that others may change the ways they think and act with regards to language diversity (Charity, 2008). We invite nonlinguist audiences to explore, engage with, and appreciate the validity of the social, historical, and lived experiences of the speakers who use a variety of dialects. Through the LDA, we have implemented several programs in compliance with NC State's institutional review board policies to move closer to these goals; in this chapter, we present a few case studies to facilitate others in their endeavors to build and maintain linguistic outreach programs at their own institutions and communities.

The first case study covers the Language Diversity Enrichment Program (LDEP), a week-long, daily summer camp designed to introduce high school students, who are frequently multidialectal and attending public schools in the Raleigh area, to linguistic diversity as well as provide them the opportunity to reflect on their own lived experiences in relation to their linguistic practices. The goals of this program are to get young people to think about language and linguistics in their own lives and to make linguistics more accessible to a wider audience outside of the academy. We present this case study as an example of a week-long engagement with multiple days of planned curriculum and opportunities for student reflection and follow-up. We aspire for this chapter to provide an adaptable template for those hoping to implement similar programs in their own communities.

The second case study details a recurring program, College Mentors for Kids (CMK), where representatives from the LDA teach and facilitate activities with groups of students from local public elementary schools in

kindergarten through fifth grade as part of a pre-existing after-school program. These students came from a variety of racial and socioeconomic backgrounds. The CMK programs were designed to get elementary-aged students to begin thinking critically—and to get excited—about their own linguistic experiences, as well as to scaffold early outreach experience for the LDA facilitators. In many cases, a K-12 student's first formal introduction to the ideas of linguistic diversity and appreciation can only happen through short-term engagements, so we provide this case study as a model for one-time workshop-style activities that can be optimized for all ages.

This chapter has two main aims. First, we present two outreach efforts planned and implemented by the LDA at North Carolina State University, along with their limitations and challenges. Second, we provide clear overviews of how we facilitated these programs, so that others may reflect upon and incorporate these ideas about linguistic variation and subordination into their own linguistic outreach and advocacy endeavors.

Background: Language Diversity Ambassadors

One focus of our outreach efforts is educating local communities at North Carolina State University and the surrounding city of Raleigh about the role that language variation plays in oppressive power dynamics, such as those broadly described by Pierre Bourdieu (1991). These efforts echo Paulo Freire's notion of critical pedagogies (1994; 2000), or the idea that educating is, in and of itself, a political act that is grounded in sociohistorical and cultural contexts and can be used to foster and further social justice efforts. We operationalize a particular kind of critical pedagogy, critical language pedagogies. Amanda Godley and Jeffrey Reaser (2018) described critical language pedagogies as educational practices which work to advocate for individuals who participate in marginalized linguistic communities. This set of practices centers language ideologies and their relationship to broader power structures, and educational materials focus on having students critically examine these concepts. By foregrounding these ideas in our outreach curricula, we aim to provide spaces where students can learn more about—and celebrate—their own linguistic practices.

Crucially, our efforts aim to change language ideologies that link linguistic variation to power imbalances; however, these practices are not without their difficulties. Educators who subscribe to the idea of, and utilize, asset-based approaches generally believe that a student's linguistic and communicative background is an inherent benefit to learning the standardized variety of

English typically taught in language arts curriculum (MacSwan, 2020). While most socially focused linguists and language educators are probably keyed in to this idea already, some asset-based approaches at times can detract from some social realities. For example, as outlined in Django Paris (2012), an effective linguistic asset-based approach is one that works to embrace, explore and sustain the cultural practices and contexts in which a language or dialect is used. Further, Django Paris and H. Samy Alim (2014) proposed that language pedagogies that engage with the sociocultural and historical aspects of language use must recognize and teach language's dynamic and unique relationship to social and political power and racial and ethnic identity construction and maintain a self-critical component as to foster and promote continued, progressive, inclusive educational efforts. Additionally, Jonathan Rosa and Nelson Flores (2017) emphasized that educational practices which *prima facie* appear to be inclusive in nature, such as the recognition and inclusion of nonhegemonic English features in speech and language screeners for children, still position non-Anglo varieties of English as variant and Other in nature. In sum, even the inclusion of asset-based approaches can still fail to meet the needs of students. As language diversity ambassadors, we continually work to recognize the precarious territory in which our efforts may exist.

While our efforts can be traced back to these theoretical roots, such work would not be possible without the foundation that previous linguistics-based educational outreach efforts have provided, especially by previous efforts of the organization now known as the North Carolina Language and Life Project (NCLLP). The idea that linguists should give back in some way to communities and language users from whom language data is collected was popularized by William Labov's (1982) principles of error correction, in which he proposed that linguists have an ethical obligation to push back against harmful, popularly held linguistic prejudices. We also adopt Labov's principle of debt incurred, which proposes that linguists who obtain data from a community are obligated to share these findings with that community. Generally, Labov argued that linguists should not be "neutral investigators" of language, but instead that linguists should take an active role in community engagement, whether by demystifying linguistic misinformation or by advocating for communities to learn more about their language practices.

Walt Wolfram (1998) broadened the scope of these principles by proposing the principle of linguistic gratuity. This principle states that linguists who engage in community-based research should work both to critically examine the community-researcher relationship and to cultivate a mutually beneficial and collaborative relationship, wherein a community may also receive symbolic, economic, or cultural capital for their time, energy, and data. Such efforts can

include the creation of sociolinguistic-based course curricula; the publication of documentaries where community members can discuss the history, cultural practices, and lived experiences of community members; the creation of language exhibits to be displayed in prominent community hubs; and perhaps most importantly, the cultivation of the personal relationships between researchers and community members (Wolfram et al., 2008). It is imperative that researchers recognize that language is an integral component of culture that is not severable from the people and communities that use it (see also Plumb et al., 2024; Riestenberg et al., 2024).

While the NCLLP has established itself within the North Carolina State University Linguistics Program as a semi-independent not-for-profit organization, many of the targeted outreach events and programs have been, and continue to be, graduate student-led. One such effort includes the Educating the Educated program on the university's campus (Dunstan et al., 2015). This program included crafting and presenting targeted, interactive workshops for undergraduate students aimed at addressing various linguistic-based misconceptions and misinformation, as well as surveying workshop participants to note what parts of the workshop were most beneficial or impactful, which areas could be improved upon, and most importantly, what students took away from these programs. Stephany Dunstan and colleagues (2015) also suggest the use of a campus infusion model that highlights pathways across university campuses where linguistic diversity work can have the highest impact, including student and academic affairs offices, diversity and inclusion offices, and human resources departments. These programs were implemented as workshops or trainings for a variety of key groups, including new staff hires in these offices and new first year students at NC State. Ongoing outreach efforts, featuring informational booths at the university's welcome week and a dedicated linguistic diversity week each year, were implemented by the Linguistic Diversity Ambassadors (LDA).

The LDA organization was founded and is led by graduate students and supervised by faculty. Described in detail in Dunstan and colleagues (2018), the LDA provides its members with professional development, outreach, and advocacy opportunities outside of the coursework and research typically associated with graduate school. With respect to professional development, students can collectively and synergistically brainstorm potential workshops for the campus community, craft cross-platform advertising and social media marketing campaigns for various events, and build and increase interinstitution and intrainstitution participation by reaching out to various departments and venues on and off the NC State campus. Due to the nature of its inception and continued leadership, the focus and mission of the LDA

has been, and continues to be, peer-to-peer linguistics education. In particular, LDA members are “encouraged to bring their own ideas to the table for creatively presenting [linguistic] information to their peers, and additionally to seek opportunities for partnerships on campus based on their interests and skillsets” (Dunstan et al., 2018, p. 218). In addition to participating heavily in this program, the LDA has also spearheaded many other on-campus and off-campus initiatives. It has led many events such as informational booths at the university’s welcome event and the North Carolina State Fair, language diversity teaching in a public school on Ocracoke Island in the Outer Banks for 30 years, and on-campus workshops covering topics ranging from queer linguistics to code-switching, and screening documentaries (Dunstan et al., 2018; Wolfram & Dunstan, 2021). Members of the LDA, including the authors, have historically come from a wide variety of racial, ethnic, socioeconomic, sexual orientation, regional and linguistic backgrounds. We are of the opinion that these variable experiences strengthen our ability to communicate with wider audiences.

The institutional structure that supports these efforts is key to enabling graduate students to occupy important roles within the LDA. By empowering graduate students to seek out, develop, and facilitate linguistic outreach programs, not only does the LDA create a space to disseminate findings from linguistic research and share individual linguistic experiences, but this organization also provides an example of how outreach and advocacy efforts can arise when a group of students wanting to make positive changes in their community organize their collective efforts and are supported in therein by like-minded faculty. The programs we discuss below were entirely graduate student-led from conception to implementation. Giving graduate students the opportunity to directly interact with individuals and communities foregrounds the LDA’s mission in the training of future language scientists, such that graduate students are immersed in local language communities from the very beginning of their time at NC State (cf. Franz et al., 2022).

The LDA works to educate individuals about their own linguistic practices to help fight linguistic prejudice (Lippi-Green, 2012) and biases at an ideological level. The importance of education-based linguistic empowerment for community members cannot be overstated, especially in the context of efforts to bring the voices of marginalized individuals into conversation with scholarship in the academy. Service to one’s community is fundamental to being a responsible social scientist, especially in the context of education about social inequalities and their manifestations in people’s everyday lives. By advocating for people in their linguistic practices (Wolfram, 2013; Wolfram & Waldorf, 2019, we interrogate and engage in collective dialogues

about power discrepancies and how they are constructed and reinforced by linguistic practices. Developing self-awareness of one's own linguistic biases, ideologies, and practices allows for critical examination of what role the individual plays in combating systemic issues like linguistic subordination and discrimination.

Language Diversity Education Program for High Schoolers

The first case study we present is the Language Diversity Education Program (LDEP), an educational summer camp for high schoolers run by the LDA since 2017. The program was suspended in 2019 and restarted in 2021. This week-long, half-day camp is designed to bring linguistics to public education beyond single-event engagements (e.g., one-time class lectures by LDA members at local high schools) and make linguistics more accessible to high school students (see also Plackowski, this volume). LDEP is free and open to any interested high schooler: we have been able to reach students from other states visiting North Carolina for the summer, students from more rural areas of North Carolina, and students from both public and private schools in the local Raleigh area. Transportation is not provided, but some schools arrange transportation for their own students who attend in larger groups. It's worth noting that some schools have a requirement for students to complete a summer program. This requirement drove many students toward our program as it was more financially accessible than other programs in the state.

In a fundamental sense, LDEP aims to implement the Students' Right to Their Own Language resolution (NCTE & CCCC, 1974/2014). This statement is central to LDA's mission, given that one major focus of the outreach program is communicating that linguistic diversity should be celebrated instead of stigmatized, especially in educational spaces. Additionally, in this program we seek to instruct students about linguistic diversity in North Carolina as a whole, connecting students to the state's history, cultures, people, and regions. Having students think critically about language and variation was essential to the goals of this curriculum, such that students could seek to evaluate and reevaluate their own language attitudes. Finally, we hope that the curriculum will spur future interest in language and linguistics among young people. This program is aligned with broader goals proposed by the Linguistics in the School Curriculum Committee of the Linguistic Society of America, including encouraging young people to think critically about language variation.

The LDEP curriculum is planned with the following structure: (1) introducing topics for preliminary discussion; (2) prompting students to share and incorporate their lived experiences; and (3) encouraging discussion and interactive activities. Although the topics change from year to year based on graduate students' areas of interest and expertise, the specific educational tools we've used so far have been mostly consistent. These tools are intended to maximize student engagement by gauging students' ideas and thought processes.

One tool that has been especially fruitful is linguistic surveys, which provide insights into students' thoughts and opinions prior to beginning an activity and then again after completing an activity. By assessing students' pre-existing perspectives, we are better able to meet students where they are with respect to their experiences. The post-activity surveys allow us to determine the students' biggest takeaways from the lesson. Students also complete exit tickets each day, which are used to identify the biggest takeaways from that day's class, which in turn allow us to adjust future days' curriculum to reiterate key concepts, to incorporate more information about topics that students had shown interest in, and to reflect on our teaching tools to better serve students' learning styles. Finally, we invite students to journal to reflect on what they had learned or topics they were thinking about. Journaling activities are mostly unstructured to permit students to freely record their thoughts and questions. At the end of the program, students are given the option to either keep their journal or share it with the facilitators, and most students chose to share their journal with the facilitators.

All students are taught basic linguistic concepts, with a focus on descriptivism versus prescriptivism and linguistic discrimination. We always cover several language varieties, including African American Language, American Sign Language, Spanglish in North Carolina, and regional North Carolina dialects (Appalachian, Outer Banks, etc.). Students are first introduced to relevant vocabulary, including *linguist*, *accent*, and *dialect*. Central to these introductory endeavors was learning about students' experiences with each topic, including their perceptions of their own accent, their knowledge of code-switching, and linguistic profiling (Baugh, 2000; Baugh, 2016). We also use professionally produced videos to introduce students to linguists working on diverse topics, especially through the North Carolina Language and Life Project (NCLLP).

Students also participate in interactive exercises that range widely by year. One activity involves the students completing draw-a-map activities for learning about perceptual dialectology, especially in the context of North Carolina. Through this activity, students are able to learn about language ideologies by critically comparing their perceptions to others'. One

year, students took part in an ultrasound activity in which they were able to view their own articulations of speech sounds in real-time and learn about the physiology of language. Various group activities, skits, and discussions are also interspersed to facilitate the exchange of ideas and feedback among peers.

The logistics of putting together this experience for high schoolers are arranged by the LDA graduate students with the help of faculty. Advertising has consisted of connecting with high school guidance counselors, hanging flyers in public libraries, and using word of mouth among graduate student and faculty contacts. Social media advertising has also been used in the past, along with promotional materials on the NC State's Linguistics Program website.

One important aspect of LDEP is the range of experiences the graduate student facilitators bring to the program. Some facilitators have no teaching experience, while others have previously worked in public schools or taught at the university level as a teaching assistant. Individual facilitators design their own lessons in collaboration with the other graduate students and faculty, and emphasis is placed on recognizing LDEP students' existing experiences as forms of linguistic expertise. Treating students as fellow scientists from the beginning of the program allows learning to go both ways, with both facilitators and students sharing their experiences and gaining new insights into language and its complexities. This framing of the program helps participants more seriously reflect on the program's content and goals.

In both journal entries and exit surveys, participants have reported they have learned about the role that language ideologies play in their evaluations of linguistic variation, especially in the context of how they think about dialects that have been historically stigmatized. Through their ongoing journals, participants often shared that the curriculum had changed the way they thought about their own dialect usage in educational settings. Participants have also reported feeling like their own linguistic experiences were both valued and validated by the facilitators. We present this case study as an example template for how we designed and executed a curriculum over the course of a week. Multiday programs are a wonderful way to incorporate different topics, cater to the interests of your audience, and take advantage of feedback and follow-up. We hope the LDEP program will inspire and guide readers who want to create a program tailored to their own communities.

The College Mentors for Kids Program

Our second case study is the College Mentors for Kids (CMK) program, which is an example of a shorter or workshop-style community outreach event. One-time or short-term workshops have different audiences and purposes

than longer-style programs like the summer camp detailed above. In this program, organized by other students at NC State, college students from outside of LDA are paired with elementary school student partners. The pairs meet for weekly activities that focus on introducing the children to higher education and careers, culture and diversity, and community service. The LDA group partnered with the CMK group for several sessions to facilitate activities for their culture and diversity focus area. We describe these sessions below.

The audience for the College Mentors for Kids program is elementary students in downtown Raleigh. Between 40 and 50 total students engage in these outreach programs split between two age groups: kindergarten to second grade and third to fifth grade. While the teaching objectives are similar for the two age groups, the activities are adjusted to be age-relevant for each group, and each session lasts for two hours. Most of the activities the LDA have completed with the students have been inspired by linguistic outreach programs at other universities, such as Ohio State's Buckeye Language Lab at the Center of Science and Industry Museum in Columbus (Wagner et al., 2015). Facilitators collaborate on designing the activities for each two-hour session.

The goals for these sessions are threefold: to get students to think critically about language, to get them excited about language, and to get them to engage with their own linguistic practices and experiences. Especially with respect to the third goal, we focus on having the students place themselves and their language use in the broader realm of linguistic diversity. Like the linguistics summer camp for high schoolers, we aim to facilitate two-way learning, such that both the facilitators and the children leave the sessions thinking more critically about language. These workshops are the first or one of the first outreach facilitation experiences for some LDA members, introducing them to community-based approaches to linguistic diversity. Additionally, the LDA facilitators are expected to educate themselves about engaging with the local community and its linguistic practices, to connect to the language communities to which the kids belonged. Facilitators prepare for the program by reading several key articles about linguistic outreach from the NCLLP and discussing best practices with Walt Wolfram, the program's faculty director (Charity, 2008; Wolfram et al., 2008; Wolfram, 2013; Dunstan et al., 2018; Hazen, 2018).

This case study presents a template both for a two-hour workshop and for adjusting linguistic diversity curricula for different age groups. Learning about language and linguistic diversity and empowering others in their own language is important for all ages, so it is essential that the lessons and activities are appropriately adjusted to be engaging for their intended audiences. A few of the LDA members had backgrounds in teaching and education, and

they were able to adjust activities appropriately for different audiences. The CMK program additionally serves as the first outreach experience for many LDA facilitators. To connect with the community and empower others to think critically about language ideologies at every age level, those who wish to do such outreach need a place to practice learning-by-doing from the facilitator standpoint. A shorter workshop-style event with both new and experienced facilitators acts as scaffolding for longer and more complex outreach events.

Both age groups individually engage with two broad activities before moving on to age-specific activities targeted for each age group. The first broad activity category for both age groups is lexical variation. This activity consists of projecting pictures of everyday items on a screen and soliciting students' words for them (e.g., *soft drink/soda/pop/coke*, *tennis shoes/sneakers/gym shoes*, *trunk/boot*). We also prompt students to think about whether they use different words in different social contexts, like at home, with friends, or at school. Facilitators also show maps from the *New York Times* dialect quiz pertaining to these lexical differences (Katz & Andrews, 2013) to show how vocabulary for the same things can differ geographically. We treat this activity as a gateway to the acknowledgment and acceptance of language variation as a natural phenomenon, as well as an opportunity for the students to connect with their own everyday experiences. Facilitators also use these discussions to transition from talking about strictly lexical variation to other aspects of dialects, such as phonological variation.

The second broad activity category is an exploration of American Sign Language (ASL). Children, all of whom so far have been hearing and unfamiliar with ASL, are taught the ASL alphabet, how to sign their own names with fingerspelling, and how to sing "Happy Birthday" in ASL. These activities introduce students to different language modalities in a way that is fun and hands-on. Because Deaf and Hard of Hearing communities are frequently marginalized, these short activities are helpful for providing students the opportunity to engage with linguistic communities that they are less familiar with.

For the younger group, facilitators lead a wug-creation activity. The children are shown a picture of a wug following Jean Berko's (1958) model, then asked to create the plural form of "wug." Facilitators point out that the children know how to create the plural without knowing the word. Then, students are invited to create their own wugs (or other funny creatures) out of paper and art supplies and name the creature themselves (Farris-Trimble & Reid, 2018). Finally, children share their newly named creatures and their appropriate plurals with the group. We chose this activity for the younger children

to keep them physically engaged in an activity and entertained while still learning. Students can also take their creations home, potentially spurring conversations with caregivers about the activity they had completed. This activity functions to validate the linguistic knowledge of students before completing other activities about linguistic diversity.

For the older group, facilitators lead several activities relating to linguistic subordination and discrimination. The first activity invites students to recognize and critically evaluate language ideologies in video clips from movies and television. The children view clips of stereotyped characters (e.g., Scar's evil/smart British accent in *The Lion King*, Foghorn Leghorn's dumb/silly Southern accent from *Looney Tunes*) and then are asked to describe traits associated with different accents. Connecting with students using media they are already familiar with fosters more critical engagement, and this design also allows students to understand the assumptions and associations that people make about specific language varieties. Finally, we seek to challenge children's stereotypes about what someone's accent says about their personal traits, helping them connect the ideas from the activities to their current language spaces.

The second activity geared toward the older children serves as a continuation of the conversation about linguistic discrimination and directly addresses discrimination through linguistic profiling (Baugh, 2000; Baugh, 2016). Facilitators play a video of a Department of Housing and Urban Development fair housing Public Service Announcement, which is widely used in discussions of linguistic profiling (The Language & Life Project, 2008). In the video, a white man calls a landlord to ask about an apartment for rent. The man uses different racially and ethnically marked accents and gets rejected over and over until he uses a more recognizably white accent and is told the apartment is still available for rent. The students first listen to the video without visuals so that they couldn't see it was one talker using different accents and are asked what they believe is the topic of the Public Service Announcement. This prompts students to think about what they were hearing and why the landlord's response to the final voice is different, preparing them for a conversation about linguistic profiling and discrimination. Facilitators then play the same video but now with both the audio and its accompanying visuals. The students can often identify the message of discrimination but have expressed surprise at seeing all the voices coming from one person, which highlights the kinds of information we can pick up and assume from hearing an accent.

In addition to introducing children to the concept of linguistic profiling in general, we also seek to present linguistics as a way to engage with social inequalities. We emphasize the idea that seemingly harmless assumptions

or associations about language can perpetuate social inequalities. Through this activity, the facilitators drive home the importance of acceptance of and appreciation for linguistic diversity, encouraging children to recognize and combat linguistic discrimination in their everyday lives.

Conclusion

The programs that we have discussed in this chapter specifically built upon existing efforts and models of linguistic outreach that have been implemented by the North Carolina Language and Life Project, such as its annual week-long curriculum taught by faculty and graduate students at Ocracoke School in the Outer Banks of North Carolina (Wolfram, Reaser, & Vaughn, 2008). The materials we have developed for the LDEP and CMK programs are available on the supplemental website associated with these volumes, as one of our aims is to facilitate the growth of language science outreach programs at other universities and educational institutions.

In doing this work, we stand on the shoulders of many dedicated linguists, activists, and outreach professionals. However, we are not the only student group that focuses on language and social justice-based efforts. For example, several efforts at the College of William & Mary and the University of California, Santa Barbara, have also worked to promote the inclusion of historically marginalized groups in linguistics and to implement student-centered mentorship programs in linguistics in addition to various linguistic outreach events (Franz et al., 2022). Phillip Carter (2018) also noted how mass media outlets can be a powerful tool for linguistic outreach via a case study of a Hispanic-serving Institution. It is our sincere hope that the two case studies that we outline in this chapter will be helpful to those who wish to engage with their own communities about language variation, change, and ideology, and perhaps most importantly, who desire to create a world where it is a bit easier to do linguistic work that matters.

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